

Auxiliaries and Time Markers

Prepared by: Peter Mangiaracina

A reference guide to English auxiliaries and common time markers.

English Tenses – Auxiliaries & Time Markers

Tense / Form	Auxiliary	Typical Time Markers / Signals
Present Simple	do / does	usually, always, often, sometimes, every day, every week, on Mondays, rarely, never
Present Continuous	am / is / are + -ing	now, right now, at the moment, currently, today, this week
Past Simple	did	yesterday, last week, last year, ago, then, in 2010
Past Continuous	was / were + -ing	while, when (background action), at that time
Present Perfect Simple	have / has + past participle	already, yet, just, ever, never, so far, up to now, recently, lately, for , since
Past Perfect Simple	had + past participle	by the time, until then, already
Future (will)	will	tomorrow, next week, soon, one day, in the future, I think...
Future (going to)	am / is / are going to	plans, intentions, predictions based on evidence
Future Continuous	will be + -ing	this time tomorrow, at 5pm next week
Future Perfect	will have + past participle	by..., within..., by the time...

Modals (as auxiliaries)

Modal	Auxiliary Form	Typical Uses / Time Hints
can	can	present ability / general possibility
could	could	past ability, polite request, possibility
may	may	permission, possibility

Modal	Auxiliary Form	Typical Uses / Time Hints
might	might	weaker possibility
must	must	strong obligation, logical deduction
have to	have to	necessity / obligation
should	should	advice / recommendation
ought to	ought to	moral obligation
would	would	past habits, polite requests, unreal / hypothetical situations